The Bullet Club Effect

Measuring the Footprint of Professional Wrestling's Most Influential Modern Faction, 2013–2026

Research draft based on the Bullet Club Impact Database

Abstract

This study asks whether Bullet Club was a successful New Japan Pro-Wrestling (NJPW) stable or an organization whose reach extended across the wrestling industry. Using a research workbook of 69 roster entries, 21 subgroups, 88 title and award entries, and merchandise and audience disclosures, it documents the group's expansion across seven partner promotions, its commercial performance, and its lineage into AEW, WWE and Impact/TNA. It then builds a transparent four-part annual footprint index and tests how sensitive the identified peak year is to the weights chosen. The index peaks in 2023 under equal weights, but that result is not robust: it reverts to 2017 when merchandise is weighted more heavily or audience data are excluded, and the 2023 score reflects the recovery of AEW quarter-hour ratings rather than demonstrably larger reach. The evidence supports the claim that Bullet Club's footprint extended well beyond a single promotion. It does not establish that Bullet Club caused AEW or any other industry change.

1. Introduction

Bullet Club formed in NJPW on May 3, 2013, around Prince Devitt, Bad Luck Fale, Karl Anderson and Tama Tonga, and was dissolved on January 5, 2026. Over those thirteen years it passed through five leadership eras and produced a family of subgroups, imitators and successors. The central question here is one of scope: did the group remain a successful faction inside one company, or did it become a structure that moved talent, merchandise and audiences between promotions?

The analysis is deliberately conservative. Every figure comes from the workbook, which records its source and disclosure status. Where a quantity is not public, such as exact merchandise revenue or NJPW World viewership, the workbook says so and this report does not estimate it. Claims are labelled as documented, or as interpretation.

2. Data and method

The workbook combines a roster chronology, official subgroups, championships, a timeline of milestones, merchandise disclosures, audience and ratings figures, and a register of gaps. Roster dates give the number of members active in each calendar year, counting a member from the year of joining through the year of leaving, inclusive. Table 1 summarizes how much of what a full study would want is actually available.

Area	Coverage	Consequence for analysis
Roster and subgroups	Complete within the public roster source	Supports year-by-year roster counts
Titles and awards	Itemized, but undated	Cannot be placed in a yearly index
Merchandise units	Selected disclosures, 2016–2024	Strong for 2017; absent in most years
Merchandise revenue and profit	Not publicly disclosed	No revenue claim is made
AEW quarter-hour ratings	Recovered for 2023–2024 only	Drives the audience measure in 2023
NJPW World, ROH and TNA segments	Not disclosed or fragmentary	No audience comparison across eras

Table 1. Data coverage in the Bullet Club Impact Database.

The annual footprint index combines four measures: roster size, count of timeline milestones, merchandise units (square-root scaled because 2017 dominates), and audience peak (the base-10 logarithm of the largest attendance or viewer figure for the year). Each measure is divided by its maximum so that its best year equals 1, and the index is a weighted average scaled to 0–100. The index is a measure of *documented footprint*. Because absent data score zero, it is sensitive to what researchers happened to recover. For that reason the report tests the result against 10,000 randomly drawn weight vectors (uniform on the simplex) and six named weighting schemes.

3. Expansion

Roster size rose from 10 active members in 2013 to a high of 32 in 2025, with a second plateau of 31 in 2023 and 2024 (Figure 1). Growth was not confined to Japan. Figure 2 shows the group's documented presence by promotion: partnerships with CMLL in Mexico from 2013, ROH in the United States from 2014, NJPW Strong from 2020, Impact/TNA and AEW from 2021, and NJPW Tamashii in Australia and New Zealand from 2022. WWE appears as a destination for alumni, not as an official Bullet Club branch.

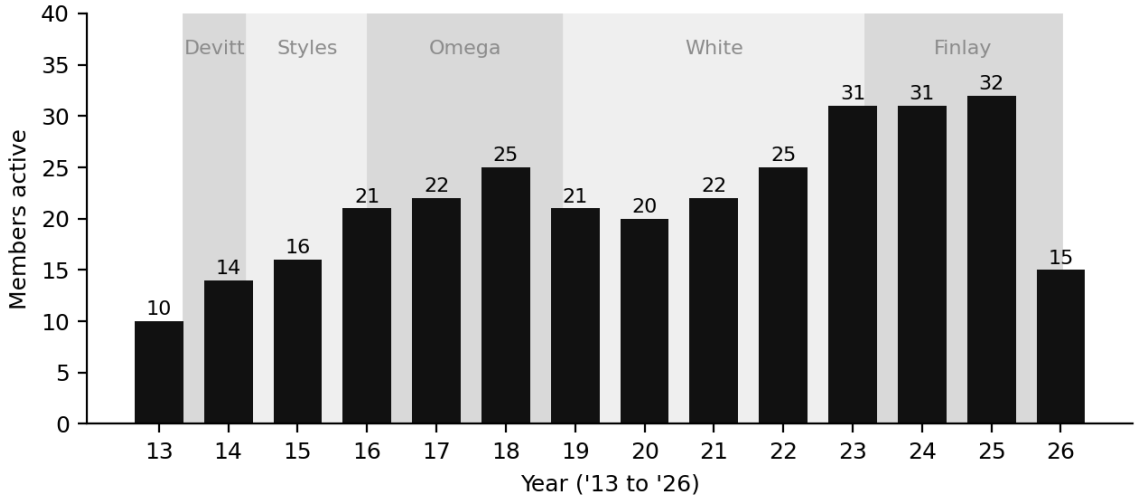


Figure 1. Members active per calendar year, with approximate leadership eras (Devitt, Styles, Omega, White, Finlay) from workbook dates. White's and Finlay's eras overlap in the roster record; the boundary shown is approximate.

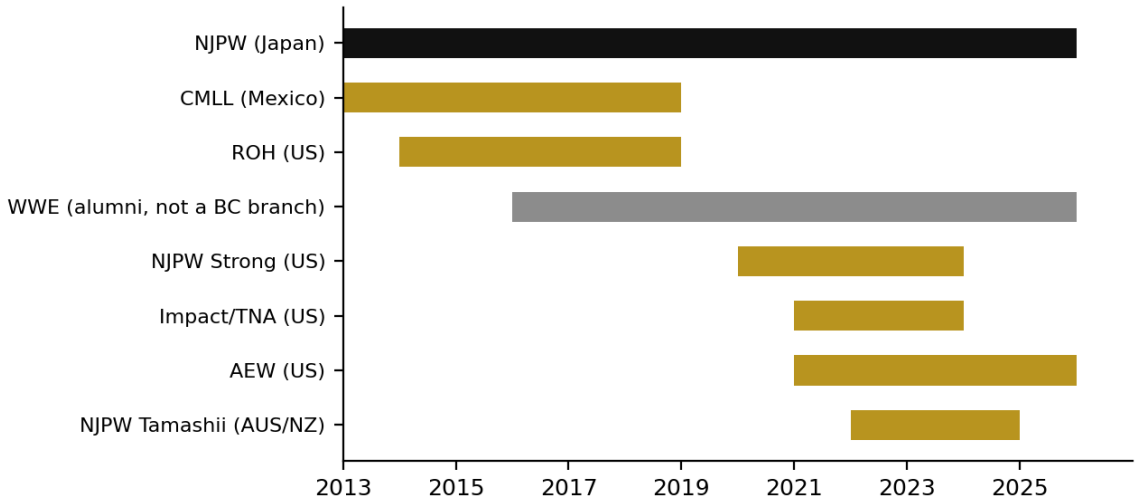


Figure 2. Documented period of Bullet Club presence by promotion, from the Promotion Impact sheet. WWE shown in grey because it is an alumni destination, not an official branch.

4. Commercial performance

The merchandise record is the strongest commercial evidence in the workbook, though it contains no revenue figure. The owner of Pro Wrestling Tees (PWT) reports more than 106,000 classic Bullet Club shirts through ecommerce alone, excluding retail, live events and direct sales. In 2017 Hot Topic initially ordered 11,600 shirts across the three designs described by Matt Jackson in a first-person account, and reordered 65,000 about three months later, a 5.6-fold increase (Figure 3). Wrestler-level rankings follow the same pattern: six of PWT's top ten wrestling merchandise sellers for 2018 were current or former Bullet Club or Elite members, including the top four. On May 3, 2021, Bullet Club Day, 30 of PWT's top 40 items were Bullet Club products, and in 2024 Wrestlenomics tracking ranked the Bullet Club category first at PWT.

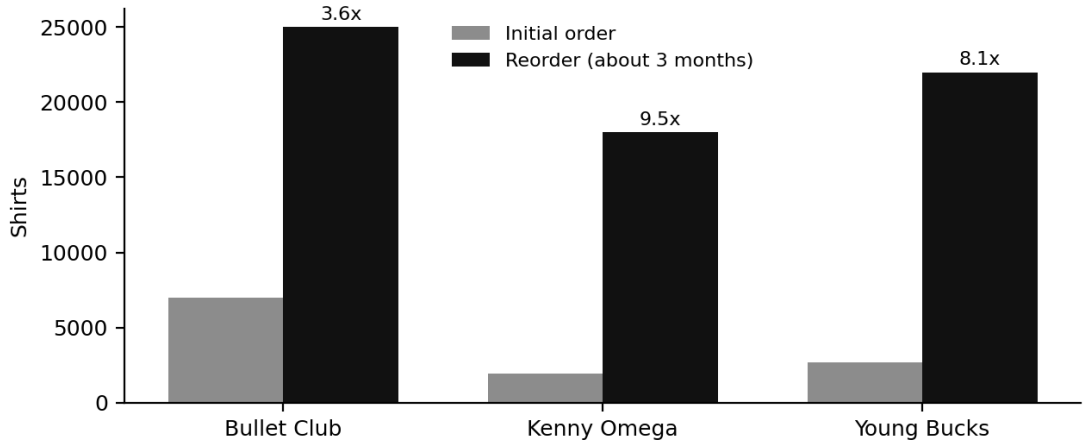


Figure 3. Hot Topic 2017 initial orders and reorders, in shirts, with the reorder multiple. Source: first-person account in the workbook; not audited retailer data.

A claim of 417,430 shirts in four months of 2017 comes from a company social-media post and is unaudited, so it is treated as a claim, not a fact. It does not drive the index: shirt-unit data exist only for 2017, so the merchandise measure is in effect a 2017 marker, and the index is identical with or without the claim (tested).

Lifetime and company-wide totals (including PWT's $75 million-plus all-wrestling figure) are context, not Bullet Club revenue.

5. The footprint index

Under equal weights the index peaks in 2023 at 74, with 2018 (62) and 2017 (55) next (Figure 4). The 2023 value is composed mainly of a large roster, the Bullet Club Gold milestones, and an audience term based on 634,000 viewers for a 2023 AEW Collision quarter. The 2018 value rests on All In's 11,263 live attendance and the 2017–2018 merchandise surge. Because the audience term compares a television quarter with a live gate, and because comparable television data exist only for 2023–2024, the 2023 peak should be read as a property of the available data as much as of Bullet Club.

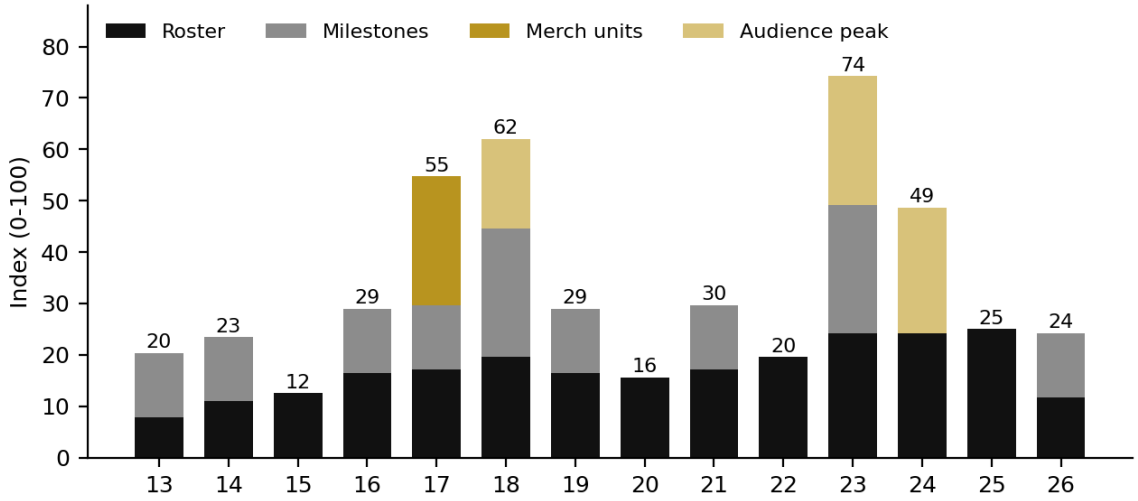


Figure 4. Annual footprint index under equal weights, shown as stacked contributions of the four measures. Missing data score zero.

The sensitivity analysis confirms this (Figure 5, Table 2). Across 10,000 random weightings, 2023 is the peak in 73.4 per cent and 2017 in 26.6 per cent; 2025 appears in three cases. The peak moves to 2017 when merchandise is weighted four times as heavily as the other measures and when audience is excluded. The honest conclusion is that two eras compete for the label of peak: a 2017–2018 commercial peak, supported by merchandise and All In, and a 2023 peak in roster size and television presence.

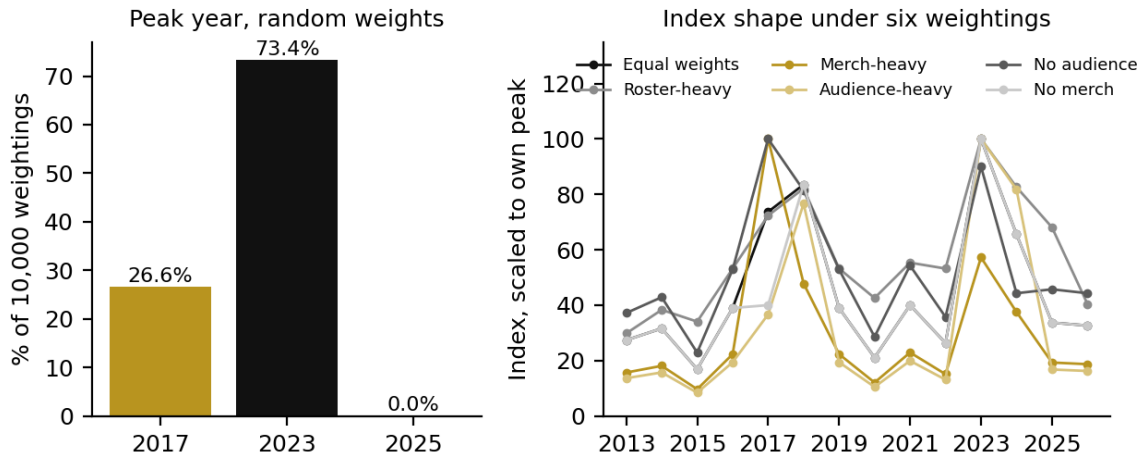


Figure 5. Left: peak year across 10,000 random weight vectors. Right: index shape under six named weightings, each scaled to its own peak.

Weighting scheme	Roster	Milestones	Merch	Audience	Peak year
Equal	1	1	1	1	2023
Roster-heavy	4	1	1	1	2023
Merch-heavy	1	1	4	1	2017
Audience-heavy	1	1	1	4	2023
No audience	1	1	1	0	2017
No merch	1	1	0	1	2023

Table 2. Peak year under six weighting schemes.

6. Lineage and the route to AEW

Figure 6 maps the documented family tree. The Elite began as a Bullet Club subgroup; AJ Styles, Luke Gallows and Karl Anderson carried the lineage into WWE as The Club and The O.C.; Tama Tonga and Tanga Loa, as G.O.D., connect to the Bloodline lineage in WWE; Jay White's Bullet Club Gold became the Bang Bang Gang in AEW; and David Finlay's War Dogs formed the final NJPW generation. WWE groups are talent lineage rather than official Bullet Club branches.

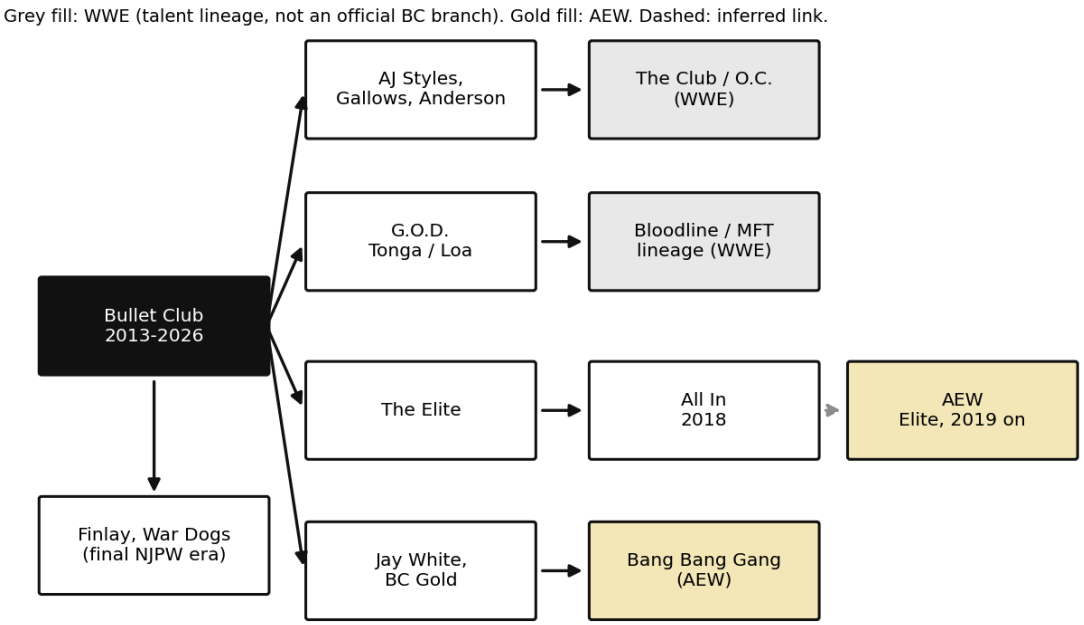


Figure 6. Documented lineage from Bullet Club. Dashed line indicates an inferred link; WWE groups are talent lineage, not official branches.

Figure 7 separates what the workbook documents from what this report interprets. Documented: the Elite's merchandise success in 2017–2018; All In in September 2018 with reported attendance of 11,263 and about 50,000 pay-per-view buys; the Elite's departure from Bullet Club on October 30, 2018; and AEW's start in 2019 with the Elite central to it. Interpretation: that this chain shows large-scale non-WWE demand which made AEW viable. The data cannot isolate Bullet Club's contribution to All In's gate or to AEW's formation.

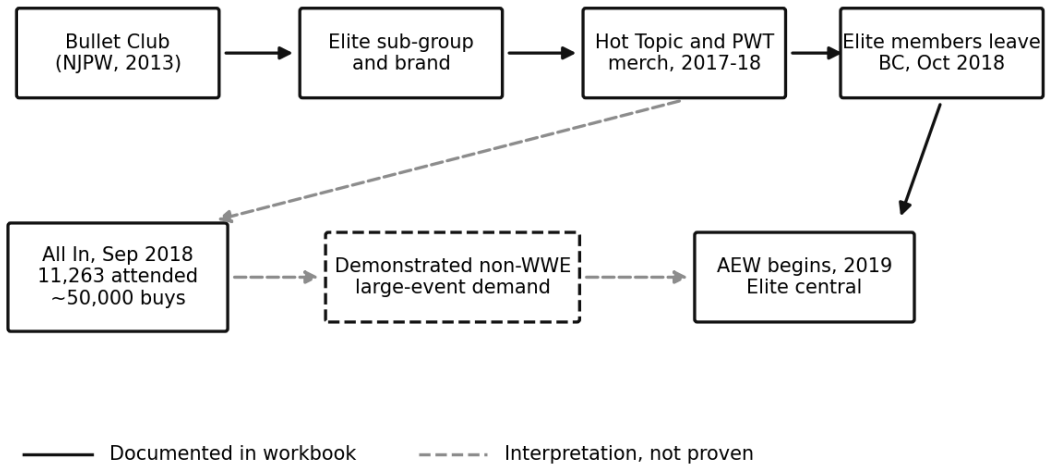


Figure 7. Causal-chain diagram. Solid arrows are documented sequence; dashed arrows are interpretation. Arrows show sequence of documented events, not demonstrated causation.

7. Limitations

Five limitations matter. First, the data are incomplete in uneven ways, so the index partly measures research coverage. Second, titles cannot be dated from the workbook, so championship success is absent from the annual model. Third, merchandise and attendance figures are drawn from memoir, company statements and secondary compilations of varying reliability. Fourth, the merchandise measure is a single-year spike because unit data exist only for 2017, so it cannot show a trend. Fifth, the analysis is observational and contains no control group, so it documents association and cannot identify causal lift. A stronger design would compare Bullet Club segments with surrounding quarters in public ratings reports, and track members' careers before and after joining.

8. Conclusion

The documented record shows a faction that operated across at least seven promotions, topped merchandise rankings in multiple years and channels, and seeded successor groups in AEW, WWE and Impact/TNA. That supports a claim of industry-wide footprint. It does not support the stronger claim that Bullet Club caused AEW or reshaped the industry, and the annual index identifies two competing peaks, not one. The most valuable next steps are to date the title reigns, recover more AEW, TNA and ROH ratings, and add control comparisons.

Sources

All data from the Bullet Club Impact Database workbook, which cites Wikipedia's Bullet Club articles and All In (2018) page, a PWT owner interview (Undisputed), Matt Jackson's memoir excerpt, TPWW, Fightful, Wrestlenomics, 411mania and Pro Wrestling.net reports. See the workbook's Sources sheet for URLs and caveats.